# Kennedy Johnston

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Texas A&M University | Department of Economics | College Station, TX 77843

## Education

**Texas A&M University** — College Station, TX
*Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.) in Economics (in progress)* — *Expected May 2027*
Dissertation Committee: Danila Serra (Chair), Catherine Eckel, Jonathan Meer, Laura Dague

**University of Nebraska-Lincoln** — Lincoln, NE
*Bachelor of Science in Business Administration* — *May 2022*
Major: Economics (Honors); Minor: Mathematics

## Research Fields

Crime; Gender; Behavioral and Experimental

## Job Market Paper

**The Under-Reporting of Sexual Assault: An Experiment on Victims, Perpetrators, and Social Judgment**
Link to Paper.
*[Pre-Registered on the AEA RCT Registry: AEARCTR-0015001; Funded by Arnold Ventures.]*

*Media Coverage:* Fighting Crime Podcast (YouTube; Spotify)

*Abstract:* Sexual assault imposes substantial economic costs, yet existing data likely understate its prevalence. I investigate how social judgment suppresses disclosure by victims and perpetrators. In an online experiment with 1,600 college students and graduates, respondents answer questions about rape and unwanted sexual contact using direct elicitation or "hard-garbling," which provides plausible deniability. Among women, deniability increases reports of non-rape victimization by 23 percent. Among men, it doubles reports of rape perpetration, with 13.1 percent admitting perpetration under hard-garbling. I also find widespread beliefs that victims may be lying and misperceptions about victim-blaming prevalence, suggesting victims anticipate negative judgment for disclosing.

## Other Working Papers

**Shaping Major Choice: The Role of High School Counselors**
*(with Jonathan Meer and Danila Serra)*
NBER Working Paper No. 35365. Link to Paper.
*[Pre-Registered on the AEA RCT Registry: AEARCTR-0004320; Funded by SSRC and CSWEP.]*

## Works in Progress

**A Crime with Little Punishment? The Likelihood of Arrest Following A Sexual Assault Report**
*Draft available upon request.*

**The Social Acceptability of Sexual Assault: A Study of Victim Identity, Hypersexualization, and the Willingness to Condemn Perpetrators**
*(with Ian Chadd)*

**The Labor Market Returns to College Grades**
*(with Jonathan Meer)*

**The Impacts of Campus Violence: Evidence from College School Shootings**
*(with Nathan Wise)*

**Sexual Assault Reporting Platforms and Social Norms: Insights from Callisto Users and an Online Experiment**
*[Pre-Registered on the AEA RCT Registry: AEARCTR-0016107; Funded by Arnold Ventures.]*

**Redefining Strength: Martial Arts, Masculinity Norms, and Girls' Empowerment**
*(with Danila Serra and Olga Shurchkov)*

## Grants

**Arnold Ventures (planning grant) – $97,387** *2024*
(*with Danila Serra)*
Title: Breaking the Silence: Under-Reporting of Campus Sexual Assault and the Role of Callisto

## Presentations

C-BID Job Market Workshop at NYU Abu Dhabi, Abu Dhabi, UAE *2026*
Columbia Gender in the Global Economy Conference (Planned), New York, NY *2026*
Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting (Planned), Houston, TX *2026*
Freiburg Ph.D. Workshop on the Economics of Criminal Behavior, Germany *2026*
The Virtual Crime Economics (ViCE) Seminar Series *2026*
Texas Economics of Crime Workshop (TxECW), Austin, TX *2026*
North-American Economic Science Association (ESA) Conference, Tucson, AZ *2025*
Annual Texas Experimental Association Symposium (TExAS), Waco, TX *2025*

## Research Experience

**Research Assistant**
Drs. Jonathan Meer and Danila Serra, Texas A&M University *Spring 2024 – present*
Dr. Danila Serra, Texas A&M University *Summer 2023*
Dr. Daniel Tannenbaum, University of Nebraska-Lincoln *Summer 2022*
Drs. Ann Mari May and Daniel Tannenbaum, University of Nebraska-Lincoln *Summer 2019*

## Teaching Experience

**ECON440: Experimental Economics**
*Instructor of Record at Texas A&M University* *Summer 2025*

**ECON441: Policy Economics**
*Teaching Assistant for Dr. Danila Serra at Texas A&M University* *Spring 2024, Fall 2026*

**ECMT461: Economic Data Analysis**
*Teaching Assistant for Dr. Craig Schulman at Texas A&M University* *Fall 2023, Fall 2025*

**ECON421: Economics of Crime**
*Teaching Assistant for Dr. Chelsea Strickland at Texas A&M University* *Fall 2022, Spring 2023*

## Referee Experience

Journal of Policy Analysis and Management

## Scholarships and Fellowships

Raymond C. Battalio Memorial Fellowship (Texas A&M University) *2026*
*Awarded to an Outstanding Doctoral Student in Behavioral Economics*

Gail Frey Monson Memorial Scholarship (Texas A&M University) *2026*
*Awarded based on Good Citizenship and Quality of Research*

MH Webber Scholarship (Texas A&M University) *2025*
*Awarded by the Private Enterprise Research Center Scholarship Committee*

John Van Huyck Fellowship (Texas A&M University) *2024*
*Awarded to Provide Support of Excellent Experimental Research*

Aviles-Johnson Graduate Fellowship (Texas A&M University) *2022*
*Awarded based on Superior Academic Record and Under-Represented Minority Status*

## Professional Service

**Economic Graduate Student Association** College Station, TX
*Second Year Representative* *August 2023 – May 2024*

**Department of Economics**, Texas A&M University College Station, TX
*First-Year Ph.D. Student Mentor* *August 2023 – May 2024*